Agricultural Marketing Service
U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

# Specialty Crop Multi-State Program

## Fiscal Year 2026 Notice of Funding Opportunity

**Funding Opportunity Number:** USDA-AMS-TM-SCMP-G-26-0020

IMPORTANT UPDATE- The application deadlines have been extended. Please refer to pages 4, 7, and 24 for revised submission deadlines. All applicants should follow the updated dates provided in this version of the NOFO.

**Publication Date: August 14, 2026**

**Application Due Date (Multi-State Partners to Participating States): 5:00 PM Eastern time on October 16, 2026**

**Application Due Date (Participating States and Entities in Nonparticipating States to AMS): 11:59 PM Eastern Time on December 4, 2026**

## 1.0 BASIC INFORMATION

**Federal Agency:** Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS)

**Funding Opportunity Title**: Specialty Crop Multi-State Program (SCMP) – Farm Bill

**Announcement Type**: Initial

**Funding Opportunity Number:** USDA-AMS-TM-SCMP-G-26-0020

**Assistance Listing Number:** 10.170

**Type of Federal Assistance:** *Grant Agreements* will be used to provide federal awards to successful applicants.

**Type of Application:** *New applications* will be evaluated competitively using the selection process and evaluation criteria described in ***section 6.0 Application Review Information***.

**Application Deadline:** The application deadline for Multi-State Partners to Participating States is 5:00 PM Eastern time on **October 16**, 2026. The application deadline for Participating States and Entities in Nonparticipating States to AMS is 11:59 PM Eastern Time on **December 4**, 2026.

Applications received after these deadlines will not be considered for funding.

### 1.1 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA), Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS), requests applications for the fiscal year (FY) 2026 Specialty Crop Multi-State Program (SCMP). AMS will competitively award funds to enhance the competitiveness of specialty crops through collaborative, multi-state projects that address the following regional or national level specialty crop issues: food safety; plant pests and disease; research; crop-specific projects addressing common issues; and marketing and promotion.

Approximately $14.3 million is available to fund applications under this solicitation. In the last application cycle in FY 2023, AMS received 88 applications and was able to fund 11 (13%) of the applications.

This announcement identifies the eligibility criteria for SCMP projects and applicants, and the application forms and associated instructions needed to apply for a SCMP grant. AMS will award these grants competitively to eligible applicants proposing high-quality projects that meet the purpose and requirements of the program. All applications will be reviewed using merit and evaluation procedures described in section ***6.0 Application Review Information***.

### 1.2 2026 HIGHLIGHTS AND CHANGES

Below are highlights of major changes to the program since the last program solicitation in FY23:

- This Notice of Funding Opportunity (NOFO) (formerly known as a Request for Applications, or RFA) was reorganized following the changes to the Uniform Guidance, Appendix I to Part 200, Title 2. The reorganization lists basic program information upfront and the application submission requirements at the end.

- The NOFO makes administrative updates for FY26 and removes language that:
    - Encourages applications that "…promotes climate-resilient landscapes and rural economic systems, including tools to support agriculture, forests, grazing lands, and rural communities."
    - Indicates applicants should "consider including goals and activities related to mitigating or adapting to climate change in their project's design and implementation...".
- The AMS General Terms and Condition(AMS GT&C) have been updated to reflect changes to the Uniform Guidance (2 CFR Part 200) and with the USDA General Terms and Conditions (USDA GT&C) for Federal Awards that were published on December 31, 2025. Both sets of General Terms and Conditions set out requirements for recipients.
    - AMS' General Terms and Conditions provide 2 CFR Part 200 and USDA GT&C citations to aid recipients on requirements.
    - Specific AMS updates reflecting 2024 Uniform Guidance updates include those to section ***6.3.1 Risk Review***, ***3.5 Allowable and Unallowable Costs and Activities ,*** and ***8.1 Administrative and National Policy Requirements***, as included in the AMS and USDA T&Cs.
- This year's applications must include a mandatory cost share from non-Federal sources in the form of cash and/or in-kind contributions, equal to 25% of the amount of Federal funds being requested. See sections ***2.4 Cost Sharing*** and ***section 4.5 Letters of Verification for Cost Sharing Funds*** for additional guidance.
- AMS also made minor updates to streamline review criteria.

## 1.3 AVAILABLE FUNDING

**Anticipated Available Funding**: Approximately $14.3 million. Enactment of future legislation may affect the availability or levels of funding for this program. There is no commitment by USDA to fund any particular application, to guarantee minimum funding levels, or to make a specific number of awards.

**Cost Share Requirement**: A cost share is required, from non-Federal sources in the form of cash and/or in-kind contributions, equal to 25% of the amount of Federal funds being requested. This cost share requirement applies to each project, whether funded through a participating State or through direct application to AMS. There is no cost share requirement for State costs to manage the program as a Participating State.

## 1.4 FEDERAL AWARD PERIOD DURATION AND SIZE

AMS expects applicants to complete their projects within the required performance period of the grant. AMS encourages applicants to use the full performance period to allow enough time to complete projects. However, a project may be completed before the scheduled performance period end date. The applicant must indicate the start date and end date on Block 17 of the SF-424 "Application for Federal Assistance."

Applicants may not request less than or more than the respective minimum/maximum amounts. Applicants must justify the requested funding amounts within the Project Narrative.

| Project types | Award Period | Start Date | End Date | Minimum award | Maximum award |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| All Project Area Types | 3 years | September 30, 2026* | September 29, 2029* | $250,000 | $1,000,000 |

*Dates are approximate. Start dates are set at the time of the award.

## 1.5 TIPS FOR APPLICANTS

- **To submit your application electronically using Grants.gov, you must:**
  - Have a Unique Entity Identifier (UEI) and a Taxpayer Identification Number (TIN);
  - Be registered in SAM.gov;
  - Provide your UEI number and TIN on your application; and
  - Maintain an active and current SAM registration.
- **Allow time for Registration Completion:**
  - The organization registration process can take **as long as four weeks.**
  - Complete the registration as early as possible to meet all deadlines. See ***section 5.0 Submission Requirements and Deadlines*** for more information.
- **Review General Terms and Conditions:**
  - Review the AMS GT&C to understand allowable and unallowable costs.
  - Review the USDA GT&C.
- **Ensure File Compatibility:**
  - Use latest version of Adobe Reader that it is compatible with Grants.gov software.
- **File Naming and Size:**
  - Limit file names to 50 characters or fewer.
  - Avoid special characters in file names ($, %, &, *, Spanish "ñ", etc.).
- **Attachment Upload:**
  - Use the “Add Attachments” button in Grants.gov for upload.
  - Do not use the “paperclip” icon in Adobe Reader.
- **File Security and Formatting:**
  - Do not password-protect files.
  - Accept all tracked changes in documents before submission.
- **Accurate Data Entry:**
  - Verify that your UEI number is correctly entered on the SF-424 form cover page.
- **Grants.gov Resources for Support:**
  - Applicant FAQs
  - Workspace Overview

By following these steps and recommendations, applicants can reduce errors, meet deadlines, and ensure compliance with submission requirements.

## 2.0 ELIGIBILITY

### 2.1 ELIGIBLE APPLICANTS

All applicants must be domestic entities owned, operated, and located within the 50 States, the District of Columbia, the Commonwealth of Puerto Rico, Guam, American Samoa, the United States Virgin Islands, or the Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands. Eligible applicants include:

| Entity Type | Description |
|---|---|
| **Participating States** | State Departments of Agriculture that elect to submit proposals to AMS on behalf of interested entities as well as oversee the administration of awarded agreements.<br><br>Note: AMS recognizes that some States may not have the resources for SCMP administration or have additional restrictions or requirements related to project costs, administration, or activities. Participating States may use Specialty Crop Block Grant Program (SCBGP) administrative funds to offset costs related to SCMP pre- and post-award activities. |
| **Nonparticipating States** | State Departments of Agriculture that do not elect to submit proposals to AMS on behalf of interested entities and will not oversee the administration of awarded agreements. |
| **Entities in Nonparticipating States** | Local governments, Indian tribes, institutions of higher education, or nonprofit organizations residing in Nonparticipating States. Entities located in a Nonparticipating State would apply directly to AMS or through the most relevant participating state |

- Entities residing in a participating state must apply through their State Department of Agriculture. Entities residing in a participating state are ineligible to apply directly to AMS.
- Entities in a non-participating state may apply to AMS directly or choose to contact the most relevant participating state to apply on behalf of the entity.
- Partnerships must include two or more states/territories.
    - The term "State," when used in this NOFO, is as it is defined in the statute ("State means the several States, the District of Columbia, the Commonwealth of Puerto Rico, Guam, American Samoa, the United States Virgin Islands, and the Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands.").

### 3.2.1 DEFINITION OF SPECIALTY CROPS

Specialty crops are fruits and vegetables, dried fruits, tree nuts, horticulture, and nursery crops (including floriculture). See the SCBGP website for a definition of specialty crops and processed products, including a list of eligible specialty crops and ineligible commodities that is applicable to this NOFO.

## 3.3 PROJECT AREA TYPES

Multi-state partners must develop projects that bring together teams for solutions to practical problems that cross State boundaries and address the needs of specialty crop growers in the areas described below. Projects should **lead to measurable benefits** for specialty crop growers, **encourage partnerships** among specialty crop organizations, and **reduce duplication of effort** among participating organizations. An SCMP project must:

1. Address one or more regional or national (multiple-State) issues described below;
2. Define the geographic target area of impact of the project such as the specific states or foreign markets;
3. Define the specific specialty crop(s) that are the focus of the project; and
4. Involves at least two partners located in different states.

### 3.3.1 FOOD SAFETY

Projects that address the handling, preparation, and storage of specialty crops in ways that reduce foodborne threats may include, but are not limited to:

- Improving detection, monitoring, control, and response to potential food safety hazards in the production, processing, and handling of specialty crops;
- Conducting research focused on issues related to (1) water quality; or (2) the use of biological soil amendments of animal origin on similar Agro-ecological regions or localities; and/or
- Strengthening regional and national traceback systems; promoting an outbreak response system that shortens the time between outbreak detection, resolution, and recovery; and improving methods for communicating with consumers about traceback of foodborne illness outbreaks.

### 3.3.2 PLANT PESTS AND DISEASE

Projects that address threats from pests and diseases may include, but are not limited to:

- Developing safe, effective, and economical pest and disease management solutions for growers of specialty crops;
- Developing monitoring systems to enhance capabilities to predict pest and disease incidence, estimate damage, and identify valid action thresholds;
- Developing treatments for quarantine pests and diseases to maintain or open healthy markets with U.S. trading partners; and/or

***Section C – Non-Federal Resources***

| Box | Instructions |
|---|---|
| 8.a – Grant Program | Field should auto-populate from Section A, Box 1.a |
| 8.b – 8.d | Enter the cost share amount being provided from each source (Applicant, State, or Other) for the project. |

## 4.4 PROJECT NARRATIVE

**Required.** Applicants MUST prepare and submit a project narrative using the Specialty Crop Multi-State Program project narrative template. The form and instructions are available on the "How to Apply" webpage or use the direct link to the template. The Project Narrative must clearly describe the objectives and goals, types of project activities, applicable outcome indicators, and fiscal plan and resources information.

The Project Narrative must be typed and single-spaced in an 11-point font. It MUST not exceed fifteen (15) 8.5 x 11 pages (excluding existing Project Narrative form content). For example, if the Project Narrative form is 15 pages before you begin entering your project information into the form, **your narrative may be up to 30 pages (15 original form pages + 15 pages of applicant content)**. DO NOT modify the SCMP Project Narrative form. Evaluation points will be deducted if the Project Narrative form is modified. Before submitting the application to Grants.gov, please make sure no tracked changes or mark-up edits and comments are visible. Handwritten applications or applications submitted in MS Word will not be accepted.

Applicants must submit the SCMP Project Narrative as a PDF and attached to the Grants.gov application package using the "Project Narrative Attachment Form" button under SF-424 item #15. Applications not submitted in the required narrative template and missing critical information will be disqualified.

**The supporting documents listed in sections 4.5 through 4.7 do not count toward the 30-page limit.**

## 4.5 LETTERS OF VERIFICATION FOR COST SHARING FUNDS

**Required**. Applicants **MUST** provide written proof of the cost share commitments from every *party*, including the applicant, who will contribute cash or in-kind cost sharing to the project.

**Submit one letter verifying the cost share for EACH cash or in-kind resource that is being contributed. The letter must be signed by the cost sharing contributor organization.** For example, if the cost share contribution will be provided by the applicant organization and two partners, a total of 3 cost share verification letters are required.

AMS has posted a Letter of Verification for Cost Share Template on the grant program's website. Applicants are strongly encouraged to use this template. If an applicant does not use this template, the cost share verification documentation must include the following:

- Project Applicant Name
- Project Title
- Cash Commitment per year (if applicable) and Total Cash Cost Share Contribution

Applications that will not be considered include, but are not limited to:

- Those from an organization that does not meet the eligibility criteria.
- Those requesting SCMP funds outside the funding range for the project type selected.
- Those missing the required documentation.
- Those submitted after the deadline.

## 6.2 REVIEW CRITERIA (TECHNICAL REVIEW)

Applications that pass the initial review screening are evaluated on their overall merit by a panel of independent peer reviewers. AMS attempts to match reviewers with applications in their areas of expertise. Each reviewer signs a conflict of interest and confidentiality agreement regarding any assigned applications. Peer review panels evaluate assigned applications using instructions prepared by AMS officials. Individual reviewers score applications and discuss with panel members to arrive at a consensus score. AMS then uses the scores as the basis for selecting applications that will go to administrative review.

**Alignment and Intent** ..... **25 Points**

1. The application provides a clear and concise description of the specific issue, problem, or need the project will address, and the objectives for the project with all written instructions and requirements described within the NOFO and Project Narrative.
2. The application demonstrates how the project will enhance the competitiveness of specialty crops through collaborative, multi-state projects that address the following regional or national level specialty crop focus areas: food safety, plant pests and disease, research, crop-specific projects addressing common issues, or marketing and promotion.
3. The application clearly indicates how it will engage with intended beneficiaries.
4. The application describes collaboration and engagement among partners that will ensure high levels of participation.

**Technical Merit** ..... **25 Points**

1. The application presents a clear, well-conceived, and suitable work plan that includes measurable or quantifiable tasks directly tied to the project goals and objectives.
2. The application provides a realistic schedule for implementing activities within the proposed award project period.
3. If the project and/or entity was previously funded, the extent to which the previous lessons learned are incorporated into the proposed project.
4. The application clearly identifies technical resources, expertise, and partners' contributions that will support project's development, implementation, and/or management; this includes the planning, conduct, and desired outcomes for training and technical assistance.

**Achievability** **20 Points**

1. The application demonstrates that the outcomes and indicator(s) are realistic and measurable for the scale and scope of the project and aligned with the project goals, including:
    a. How target indicator numbers were derived, including a clear plan for collecting data and feedback to evaluate and achieve each relevant outcome indicator.
    b. Key factors predicted to contribute to or restrict progress toward the indicators, including action steps for addressing restrictive factors.
    c. Overall viability of outcomes and indicators to ensure that they are meaningful, accessible, and can be applied and evaluated.
2. The project design can reasonably be replicated in other regions, communities, or agricultural systems.
3. The application includes a comprehensive plan to share the project's results (both positive and negative) and to share lessons learned electronically and in-person to target audiences, stakeholders, and interested parties.

**Expertise and Partners** **20 Points**

1. The application includes substantial, effective, varied, and strong qualifications of relevant partnerships and collaborators to accomplish the project's goals and objectives and to meet the needs of the intended beneficiaries including:
    a. Commitment from the key partners and/or collaborators to achieve project goals and outcomes, as demonstrated through their Letters of Commitment.
    b. Names and titles of key staff who will be responsible for managing the project and individuals who comprise the Project Team.
    c. The project team demonstrates expertise and experience necessary to successfully manage and implement the proposed project.
2. The application describes a clear management plan for coordination, communication, data sharing, managing conflicts of interest, and reporting among members of the Project Team and stakeholder groups, including both internal applicant personnel and external partners and collaborators.
3. The application describes how the project's partnerships and collaborations will be sustained beyond the grant period, such as strategies for maintaining and leveraging additional resources (i.e., without grant funds).

**Fiscal Plan and Resources** **10 Points**

1. The application budget narrative or justification provides a clear and detailed description for each budget item including:
    a. How the budget is reasonable and proportional to the size and scope of the project; and
    b. How each cost item directly supports and aligns with activities and outcomes described in the narrative.
2. The application provides evidence that critical resources and infrastructure that are necessary for the initiation and completion of the proposed project are currently in place.

3. The applicant demonstrates its contributions of non-Federal cash or in-kind resources are available for the project as evidenced through the submitted Cost Share Verification Letters.

### 6.3 ADMINISTRATIVE REVIEW (SELECTION PROCESS AND RISK REVIEW)

AMS will conduct a final administrative evaluation of each review panel's top scores applications. In addition to the scores, AMS reviews each application to ensure that potential recommended projects align with the scope of this NOFO, allowability of budget items, available funding, geographic coverage/variety and USDA priorities. AMS staff will work with top-scored applicants to negotiate any revisions as necessary and possible. AMS will also assess an organization's ability to account for the use of Federal funds and monitor the performance associated with these awards using the guidance provided in ***section 6.3.1 Risk Review.***

#### 6.3.1 RISK REVIEW

Prior to making a Federal award, AMS will review the risk of applicants in managing federal funds. AMS will review the applicant's financial stability, the quality of their management systems and standards, current and prior performance managing federal grants, audit reports and findings, the ability to effectively implement Federal award requirements, and make sure that the applicant has policies and procedures in place to manage a federal award. AMS will review the applicant's responsibility and qualification records in SAM.gov, USA Spending, Federal Awardee Performance and Integrity Information System (FAPIIS) along with any comments entered by the applicant. For additional information refer to 2 CFR 200.206.

If the applicant is found to present significant risk, AMS may choose not to fund the application or place specific conditions (2 CFR § 200.208) on the award.

AMS will follow government-wide rules which prevent making awards to applicants that have been suspended or debarred from receiving federal awards.

## 7.0 AWARD NOTICES

### 7.1 SUCCESSFUL APPLICANTS

Upon announcement of the Federal awards, AMS will prepare and send electronically a Notice of Award (NOA) to each recipient for signature by the appropriate official. The NOA will be signed by AMS and the AOR.

The NOA will provide pertinent instructions and information including, at a minimum, the information described in 2 CFR § 200.211 and reference to the AMS GT&C and USDA GT&C.

### 7.2 UNSUCCESSFUL APPLICANTS

AMS will contact unsuccessful applicants via email as soon as possible after the SCMP awards are announced. The unsuccessful applicants will receive anonymized consensus review panel comments regarding their application.